

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Rudyard Kipling · 1894

First published: The Jungle Book, 1894

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Jungle_Book_(Century_edition)/"Rikki-Tikki-Tavi" (revision 11153618), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 6–8 (middle-school track; a bridge/support-track text for grade 9, not a 9–12 core text). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about courage?
- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about protecting home?
- What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggest about nature and instinct?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Rikki-Tikki-Tavi	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*courage* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Rudyard Kipling's life or times connects to courage in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (courage, protecting home, nature and instinct).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Rudyard Kipling was born in Bombay (Mumbai), India, on 30 December 1865, was sent to England for schooling at five, and returned to India at sixteen as a journalist. His stories and poems of British India made him famous; The Jungle Book (1894), which includes "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi," was written while he lived in Vermont. In 1907 he became the first English-language writer to win the Nobel Prize in Literature. His work is admired for its craft and criticized for its celebration of empire. He died in London on 18 January 1936.

Historical and cultural context

Set in a British bungalow in colonial India (the Raj), with an English family as the mongoose's protected household. Kipling grew up partly in India.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The Jungle Book (1894), possibly earlier in magazines.

Then: Popular immediately.

Now: A beloved animal adventure, also discussed critically for its colonial viewpoint.

Overview (spoiler-free)

A young mongoose is rescued by an English family and guards their garden against two cobras, Nag and Nagaina.

Main themes

- courage.
- loyalty and protection.
- good versus evil.

Why it matters

Students learn about conflict and characterization, and can discuss perspective.

Spoilers · teacher only

Rikki kills Nag in the bathroom, destroys the eggs and follows Nagaina into her hole, killing her.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: What makes someone brave?
Prompt: Before we open Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: What makes someone brave?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
personification; conflict; protagonist and antagonist; colonialism.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Rudyard Kipling was born in Bombay (Mumbai), India, on 30 December 1865, was sent to England for schooling at five, and returned to India at sixteen as a journalist. His stories and poems of British India made him famous; The Jungle Book (1894), which includes "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi," was written while he lived in Vermont. In 1907 he became the first English-language writer to win the Nobel Prize in Literature. His work is admired for its craft and criticized for its celebration of empire. He died in London on 18 January 1936. The world of the book. Set in a British bungalow in colonial India (the Raj), with an English family as the mongoose's protected household. Kipling grew up partly in India. Publication and reception. First published in The Jungle Book (1894), possibly earlier in magazines. Then: Popular immediately. Now: A beloved animal adventure, also discussed critically for its colonial viewpoint.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Turn for turn and twist for twist —" slowly and put it in my own words: The tailorbird's song describes the fight with Nag as turn for turn and twist for twist. Next, craft. I notice the repeated paired phrases, which copy the back-and-forth movement of the fight itself. The strongest word is "twist": it captures the snake's coiling and the speed of the struggle. Then, effect. What does this line from the song about the fight suggest? My answer: Kipling makes the battle feel fast and evenly matched; Rikki wins by matching the cobra move for move, which is why the garden sings his praise.

> *Turn for turn and twist for twist — (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 9)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Turn for turn and twist for twist —" slowly and put it in my own words: The tailorbird's song describes the fight with Nag as turn for turn and twist for twist. Next, craft. I notice the repeated paired phrases, which copy the back-and-forth movement of the fight itself. The strongest word is "twist": it captures the snake's coiling and the speed of the struggle. Then, effect. What does this line from the song about the fight suggest? My answer: Kipling makes the battle feel fast and evenly matched; Rikki wins by matching the cobra move for move, which is why the garden sings his praise.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): A young mongoose is rescued by an English family and guards their garden against two cobras, Nag and Nagaina. Themes to track: courage.: loyalty and protection.: good versus evil.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: protecting home. Prediction: the young mongoose Rikki-tikki, adopted by an English family in India, will have to defend the bungalow and garden. Question: which enemy will test his courage first, and how?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: protecting home. Prediction: the young mongoose Rikki-tikki, adopted by an English family in India, will have to defend the bungalow and garden. Question: which enemy will test his courage first, and how?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi still matter? Students learn about conflict and characterization, and can discuss perspective.
Anchor question: Why might Rikki-Tikki-Tavi still be taught today?
Facilitation: Students learn about conflict and characterization, and can discuss perspective.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Kipling was born in India in 1865 and wrote this story for The Jungle Book in 1894. How might his childhood in India shape it? Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew Indian wildlife; he wrote from a British colonial perspective; the family in the story is British in India.
Exit ticket: Kipling was born in India in 1865 and wrote this story for The Jungle Book in 1894. How might his childhood in India shape it?
Answer: Accept answers such as: he knew Indian wildlife; he wrote from a British colonial perspective; the family in the story is British in India.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: Rikki-Tikki-Tavi.

Teacher notes · sources: Nobel Prize, "Rudyard Kipling: Biographical" (https://www.nobelprize.org/prizes/literature/1907/kipling/biographical/); The Kipling Society (https://www.kiplingsociety.co.uk/); Kipling Society (https://www.kiplingsociety.co.uk/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Verify any prior magazine publication before stating it; the 1894 Jungle Book is certain.

Lesson 2: Rikki-Tikki-Tavi

Focus: courage in defense of home

Objective: Students will analyze how characterization develops in "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi" by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (animal violence, colonial setting, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Animal violence; colonial setting. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug ("… at night, at dinner, walking to and fro among the wine-glasses on the table, he could have stu…"). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes animal violence; colonial setting.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy Teddy; Rikki lures her away, follows her into her hole and kills her.

Background: Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective.

Significance: A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What makes someone brave? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to courage because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes animal violence; colonial setting.
Prompt: What makes someone brave?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to courage because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: he fights a much larger enemy.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: cantonment — a permanent military station in British India; scuttled — ran with short quick steps; bungalow — a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda; cowered — crouch or curl up; frighten — cause fear in. "cantonment": Origin: French cantonnement.
Words: cantonment: a permanent military station in British India · scuttled: ran with short quick steps · bungalow: a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda · cowered: crouch or curl up · frighten: cause fear in

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective. A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification. Personification: The animals speak, scheme and grieve (Darzee the tailorbird sings victory songs; Nagaina plots revenge), so the garden becomes a battlefield with characters. Conflict: Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes. Characterization: Rikki is curious, brave and loyal; Nagaina is cunning; Darzee is foolish but loyal. Watch for the garden: an Eden with serpents in it, which Rikki defends.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "Run and find out" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator explains that the motto of all the mongoose family is "Run and find out." Next, craft. I notice it is a short, active command, not a rule to be careful. The strongest word is "find": it names his curiosity, the trait that leads him into the bathroom where Nag hides. Then, effect. What does the mongoose family motto tell us about Rikki? My answer: The mongoose family motto, "Run and find out," tells us Rikki is driven by curiosity; it makes him explore the garden, discover the cobras and fight them, so his courage grows out of his need to find out.

> *Run and find out (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "Run and find out" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator explains that the motto of all the mongoose family is "Run and find out." Next, craft. I notice it is a short, active command, not a rule to be careful. The strongest word is "find": it names his curiosity, the trait that leads him into the bathroom where Nag hides. Then, effect. What does the mongoose family motto tell us about Rikki? My answer: The mongoose family motto, "Run and find out," tells us Rikki is driven by curiosity; it makes him explore the garden, discover the cobras and fight them, so his courage grows out of his need to find out.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Battle. Look at the craft: Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes. Ask: How does this line connect to courage? Expected: He fights a much larger enemy. (Battle.)

> *Nag, come up and dance with death* *(Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Battle. Look at the craft: Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes.
Ask: How does this line connect to courage?
Expected answer: He fights a much larger enemy. (Battle.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the story for personification, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about courage in defense of home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Rikki-Tikki-Tavi develops the idea of courage in defense of home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. When the text says "Run and find out" (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20), it shows this directly. The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.
Task: Annotate the story for personification, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about courage in defense of home? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Rikki-Tikki-Tavi develops the idea of courage in defense of home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. When the text says "Run and find out" (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20), it shows this directly. The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What makes someone brave? Ask: whose point of view is missing?
Anchor question: What makes someone brave?
Facilitation: Ask: whose point of view is missing?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about courage in defense of home? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. (“Run and find out”, Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about courage in defense of home? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. (“Run and find out”, Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how personification shapes courage in defense of home. Key takeaway: he fights a much larger enemy.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Personification:** The animals speak, scheme and grieve (Darzee the tailorbird sings victory songs; Nagaina plots revenge), so the garden becomes a battlefield with characters.
- **Conflict:** Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes.
- **Characterization:** Rikki is curious, brave and loyal; Nagaina is cunning; Darzee is foolish but loyal.

Themes and how they develop

- **courage:** he fights a much larger enemy.

Symbols and motifs

- **the garden:** an Eden with serpents in it, which Rikki defends.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20) His nature.
- “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4) Battle.
- “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21) The family's acceptance.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero.
Evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20)
Reasoning: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cantonment (noun)	a permanent military station in British India	*THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.*	"cantonment": Origin: French cantonnement. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/cantonment#Etymology)
scuttled (verb)	ran with short quick steps	*Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very sorrowful voices in a thorn-bush.*	
bungalow (noun)	a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda	*THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.*	
cowered (verb)	crouch or curl up	*Darzee and his wife only cowered down in the nest without answering, for from the thick grass at the foot of the bush there came a low hiss—a horrid cold sound that made Rikki-tikki jump back two clear feet.*	
frighten (verb)	cause fear in	*"Now," said the big man (he was an Englishman who had just moved into the bungalow); "don't frighten him, and we'll see what he'll do."*	
draggled (adjective)	wet, dirty and bedraggled	*When he revived, he was lying in the hot sun on the middle of a garden path, very draggled indeed, and a small boy was saying: "Here's a dead mongoose.*	

Discussion questions

1. What makes someone brave?
2. Where does characterization appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with courage?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16,

17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How does Rikki-tikki come to the family? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A flood washes him to their garden
2. What are the cobras' names? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Nag and Nagaina
3. Who is Darzee? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A tailorbird
4. Where does Rikki kill Nag? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: In the bathroom
5. Whose life does Nagaina threaten? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Teddy's
6. Retell the three most important events of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy Teddy; Rikki lures her away, follows her into her hole and kills her.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.” What does “cantonment” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: cantonment: a permanent military station in British India.
10. Reread: “Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very…” What does “scuttled” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: scuttled: ran with short quick steps.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” suggest about courage in defense of home? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.
2. Find one example of characterization in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
3. How does the conflict in this story shape what we understand about courage in defense of home? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against

each other.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20): His nature. On conflict: Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. In the passage that begins “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, why might Kipling have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A young mongoose, washed from his burrow by a flood, is adopted by an English family in a bungalow in India. He befriends Darzee the tailorbird and learns of the cobras Nag and Nagaina. He kills the snake Karait, then Nag in the bathroom, and destroys Nagaina's eggs. Nagaina threatens the boy…
6. As the opening story, what does “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” set up that the rest of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4): Battle. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21): The family's acceptance. On characterization: Rikki is curious, brave and loyal; Nagaina is cunning; Darzee is foolish but loyal. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes someone brave?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does personification appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with courage? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Look for how this element shapes meaning.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20): His nature. On personification: The animals speak, scheme and grieve (Darzee the tailorbird sings victory songs; Nagaina plots revenge), so the garden becomes a battlefield with characters. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Published in The Jungle Book (1894). Kipling, born in Bombay, wrote from within British colonial India; teachers may discuss that perspective. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4): Battle. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A widely taught middle-school story for conflict, characterization and personification.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21): The family's acceptance. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20): His nature. On characterization: Rikki is curious, brave and loyal; Nagaina is cunning; Darzee is foolish but loyal. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Rewrite one moment of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about courage in defense of home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.6, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4): Battle. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. Write three questions of your own about “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21): The family's acceptance. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Connect this story to protecting home: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Kipling need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20): His nature. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the characterization in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4): Battle. On characterization: Rikki is curious, brave and loyal; Nagaina is cunning; Darzee is foolish but loyal. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Compare how “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi” treats courage in defense of home with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Rikki-Tikki-Tavi see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21): The family's acceptance. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve courage? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20): His nature. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about courage in defense of home? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4): Battle. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. What question would you most like to ask Rudyard Kipling about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Useful evidence: “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21): The family's acceptance. Theme link: he fights a much larger enemy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Personification**:

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose life does Nagaina threaten?
   A. Darzee's
   B. Teddy's
   C. The mother's only
   D. The father's

   Key: B (Teddy's)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"Now," said the big man (he was an Englishman who had just moved into the bungalow); "don't _____ him, and we'll see what he'll do."” Word bank: scuttled, frighten, cantonment, bungalow

   Key: frighten
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Rikki kill Nag?
   A. In the garden
   B. In the melon bed
   C. In a tree
   D. In the bathroom

   Key: D (In the bathroom)
4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21: “That's his way of making _____”

   Key: friends
5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Rikki-tikki come to the family?
   A. He walks in from the jungle
   B. He is bought at a market
   C. He is a gift
   D. A flood washes him to their garden

   Key: D (A flood washes him to their garden)
6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When he revived, he was lying in the hot sun on the middle of a garden path, very _____ indeed, and a small boy was saying: "Here's a dead mongoose.” Word bank: draggled, scuttled, cantonment, bungalow

   Key: draggled
7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What are the cobras' names?
   A. Teddy and Rikki
   B. Darzee and Chuchundra
   C. Karait and Chua
   D. Nag and Nagaina

   Key: D (Nag and Nagaina)
8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Darzee?
   A. A muskrat
   B. A tailorbird
   C. The gardener

D. A snake

Key: B (A tailorbird)

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
   Sample answer: Battle.
10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”?
    A. The hunter becoming the hunted
    B. Courage in defense of home
    C. Love measured by sacrifice
    D. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

    Key: B (Courage in defense of home)
11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: His nature.
12. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: The family's acceptance.
13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes.
    A. Conflict
    B. Point of view
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Foreshadowing

    Key: A (Conflict)
14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? The animals speak, scheme and grieve (Darzee the tailorbird sings victory songs; Nagaina plots revenge), so the garden becomes a battlefield with characters.
    A. Tone / mood
    B. Personification
    C. Characterization
    D. Allusion

    Key: B (Personification)
15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20).
    Sample answer: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Battle.
17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His nature.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how courage develops from an earlier story to “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: he fights a much larger enemy.

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very…”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?

    A. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    B. crouch or curl up

    C. a permanent military station in British India

    D. ran with short quick steps

    Key: D (ran with short quick steps)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, what does “cantonment” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    C. a permanent military station in British India

    D. crouch or curl up

    Key: C (a permanent military station in British India)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Darzee and his wife only cowered down in the nest without answering, for from the thick grass at the foot of the bush there came a low hiss—a horrid cold sound that made Rikki-tikki jump back two clear feet.”, what does “cowered” most nearly mean?

    A. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    B. ran with short quick steps

    C. crouch or curl up

    D. a permanent military station in British India

    Key: C (crouch or curl up)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	4, 1, 7, 3, 5, 8, 2, 6, 10, 9, 11, 15, 12, 14, 13, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	1, 7, 8, 6, 5, 3, 4, 2, 9, 10, 11, 12, 15, 14, 18, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 6, 3, 7, 5, 1, 4, 9, 11, 10, 13, 15, 14, 12, 19, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	2, 6, 5, 8, 1, 7, 10, 11, 9, 14, 12, 15, 13, 17, 18, 16	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	3, 20, 6, 21, 2, 11, 9, 10, 14, 12, 13, 15, 17, 19, 18, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	6, 2, 1, 22, 7, 11, 9, 10, 14, 15, 13, 12, 17, 18, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

College Sophomore	5, 2, 6, 4, 21, 9, 10, 11, 13, 14, 15, 12, 19, 16, 17, 18	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	6, 2, 3, 1, 20, 9, 10, 11, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 16, 17, 18	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	2, 4, 5, 20, 7, 10, 9, 11, 14, 12, 13, 15, 18, 19, 16, 17	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	2, 8, 3, 5, 4, 9, 11, 10, 13, 14, 15, 12, 17, 18, 19, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Rikki-Tikki-Tavi," how does Kipling show courage in defense of home? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, how does Kipling develop the idea of courage in defense of home? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Rikki-Tikki-Tavi develops the idea of courage in defense of home. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of courage in defense of home. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi suggests about courage in defense of home. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Rudyard Kipling uses characterization in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi to complicate the reader's understanding of courage in defense of home. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate Rikki-Tikki-Tavi within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of courage in defense of home responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read Rikki-Tikki-Tavi alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of courage in defense of home follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Rikki-Tikki-Tavi and its treatment of courage in defense of home. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads Rikki-Tikki-Tavi as evidence for a larger claim about courage in defense of home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads Rikki-Tikki-Tavi as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of courage in defense of home. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Rikki-Tikki-Tavi.

SAT-style questions

1. *THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “bungalow” most nearly mean?

   A. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

   B. crouch or curl up

   C. cause fear in

   D. wet, dirty and bedraggled

2. *THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment. Darzee, the tailor-bird, helped him, and Chuchundra, the muskrat, who never comes out into the middle of the floor, but always creeps round by the wall, gave him advice; but Rikki-tikki did the real fighting.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”?

   A. A boy's romantic quest ending in disillusion

   B. Wishes that defy fate

   C. Courage in defense of home

   D. A choice the reader must make

SAT key: 1. A (a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda); 2. C (Courage in defense of home)

Unit test

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21: “That's his way of making _____”

   Key: friends

2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “"Now," said the big man (he was an Englishman who had just moved into the bungalow); "don't _____ him, and we'll see what he'll do."” Word bank: scuttled, frighten, cantonment, bungalow

   Key: frighten

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does Rikki-tikki come to the family?

   A. He walks in from the jungle

   B. He is bought at a market

   C. He is a gift

   D. A flood washes him to their garden

   Key: D (A flood washes him to their garden)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “When he revived, he was lying in the hot sun on the middle of a garden path, very _____ indeed, and a small boy was saying: "Here's a dead mongoose.” Word bank: draggled, scuttled, cantonment, bungalow

   Key: draggled

5. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Where does Rikki kill Nag?

   A. In the garden

   B. In the melon bed

   C. In a tree

   D. In the bathroom

   Key: D (In the bathroom)

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Whose life does Nagaina threaten?

   A. Darzee's

   B. Teddy's

   C. The mother's only

D. The father's

Key: B (Teddy's)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What are the cobras' names?

   A. Teddy and Rikki

   B. Darzee and Chuchundra

   C. Karait and Chua

   D. Nag and Nagaina

   Key: D (Nag and Nagaina)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] Who is Darzee?

   A. A muskrat

   B. A tailorbird

   C. The gardener

   D. A snake

   Key: B (A tailorbird)

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: His nature.

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”?

    A. The hunter becoming the hunted

    B. Courage in defense of home

    C. Love measured by sacrifice

    D. A girl's first encounter with death across the class line

    Key: B (Courage in defense of home)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Battle.

12. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “That's his way of making friends” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 21). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: The family's acceptance.

13. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? The animals speak, scheme and grieve (Darzee the tailorbird sings victory songs; Nagaina plots revenge), so the garden becomes a battlefield with characters.

    A. Tone / mood

    B. Personification

    C. Characterization

    D. Allusion

    Key: B (Personification)

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”? Rikki against the cobras; each battle (Karait, Nag, the eggs, Nagaina) raises the stakes.

    A. Conflict

B. Point of view

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Foreshadowing

Key: A (Conflict)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20).
    Sample answer: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.
16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Nag, come up and dance with death” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 4) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Battle.
17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “Run and find out” (Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, paragraph 20) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: His nature.
18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how courage develops from an earlier story to “Rikki-Tikki-Tavi”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: he fights a much larger enemy.
19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “Rikki's curiosity makes him a hero.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: The mongoose motto is "Run and find out," and that drive leads him to the cobras and victory.
20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Darzee and his wife only cowered down in the nest without answering, for from the thick grass at the foot of the bush there came a low hiss—a horrid cold sound that made Rikki-tikki jump back two clear feet.”, what does “cowered” most nearly mean?

    A. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    B. ran with short quick steps

    C. crouch or curl up

    D. a permanent military station in British India

    Key: C (crouch or curl up)
21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, what does “cantonment” most nearly mean?

    A. ran with short quick steps

    B. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    C. a permanent military station in British India

    D. crouch or curl up

    Key: C (a permanent military station in British India)
22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Rikki-tikki licked his lips. "This is a splendid hunting-ground," he said, and his tail grew bottle-brushy at the thought of it, and he scuttled up and down the garden, snuffing here and there till he heard very…”, what does “scuttled” most nearly mean?

    A. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

    B. crouch or curl up

    C. a permanent military station in British India

D. ran with short quick steps

Key: D (ran with short quick steps)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “THIS is the story of the great war that Rikki-tikki-tavi fought single-handed, through the bath-rooms of the big bungalow in Segowlee cantonment.”, what does “bungalow” most nearly mean?

A. ran with short quick steps

B. a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda

C. crouch or curl up

D. a permanent military station in British India

Key: B (a one-story house, originally in India, with a wide veranda)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	5, 4, 6, 8, 7, 2, 1, 3, 11, 9, 10, 13, 15, 14, 12, 18, 16, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Sophomore	5, 3, 7, 6, 1, 4, 8, 2, 11, 9, 10, 14, 12, 13, 15, 16, 18, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Junior	7, 6, 2, 8, 3, 1, 5, 4, 10, 9, 11, 14, 15, 12, 13, 16, 18, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Senior	1, 7, 4, 6, 8, 5, 3, 2, 10, 11, 9, 15, 12, 14, 13, 18, 17, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	2, 5, 20, 21, 3, 6, 4, 10, 9, 11, 13, 15, 12, 14, 19, 17, 18, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	20, 4, 6, 3, 21, 22, 2, 11, 9, 10, 14, 12, 13, 15, 19, 16, 18, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	2, 4, 23, 1, 8, 3, 20, 10, 11, 9, 14, 15, 13, 12, 17, 16, 18, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	3, 20, 4, 21, 8, 23, 1, 9, 11, 10, 13, 15, 12, 14, 17, 19, 18, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	21, 23, 22, 2, 4, 5, 7, 9, 10, 11, 15, 13, 12, 14, 17, 18, 16, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	4, 2, 20, 6, 8, 22, 23, 10, 11, 9, 14, 15, 12, 13, 19, 17, 16, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

Rikki-Tikki-Tavi: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Rudyard Kipling develops courage across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to protecting home.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether Rikki-Tikki-Tavi finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of nature and instinct. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Courage

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about courage. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops courage across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of courage. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of courage, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of courage in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on courage in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Protecting home

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about protecting home. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops protecting home across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of protecting home. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of protecting home, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of protecting home in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on protecting home in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Nature and instinct

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Rikki-Tikki-Tavi teaches about nature and instinct. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Rudyard Kipling develops nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Rudyard Kipling develops nature and instinct across Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of nature and instinct. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Rudyard Kipling's choices in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of nature and instinct, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Rikki-Tikki-Tavi's treatment of nature and instinct in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on nature and instinct in Rikki-Tikki-Tavi, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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